SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

A QUALITATIVE STUDY ON THE LIVED EXPERIENCES OF UNLICENSED DRIVING

AND UNREGISTERED VEHICLES

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the Study

Vehicular regulations and policies in most countries globally include requirements for vehicle control, such as obtaining a valid driver's license and vehicle registration. Driving unregistered vehicles or without a license violates these policies and increases the risk for both the driver and others on the road. Unlicensed driving may stem from inability to access licensing processes, financial reasons, negligence, or intentional avoidance; unregistered cars may be due to cost, red tape, or ignorance of the law. Such practices undermine the regulatory framework intended to promote safe, responsible road use and cast doubt on legal responsibility and social justice in responses to compliance (Partulan et al., 2024a).

Around the world, studies show that people who drive without a license are more likely to get into accidents and cause injuries. Reports show that unlicensed drivers make up a bigger share of road users than expected. A U.S.-based study found that about one in five fatal crashes involved drivers who were unlicensed or had suspended or revoked licenses (Dong et al., 2017). On the same note, a case-control study established that unlicensed drivers were significantly more likely to suffer severe injuries than validly licensed drivers.

Despite the confounding factors (Blows et al., 2005). These results indicate that a driver's legal status (licensed or unlicensed) is a significant determinant of

traffic safety. However, the bulk of work done internationally is quantitative in character —determining accident rates, death rates, risk ratios, and much more. Researchers have done very few studies on people who drive without a license or use unregistered vehicles, including their reasons, challenges, and views on risk and legality.

The issue of unregistered motor vehicles in the Philippines continues to grow. As of May 2025, the Land Transportation Office (LTO) had seized 18,934 unregistered vehicles — mostly motorcycles, but also tricycles, vans, private cars, and public transport vehicles (GMA News Online, 2025). Authorities arrested 18,882 people during a similar campaign in March 2025 (Philippine News Agency, 2025). Government agencies have reinforced the "No Registration, No Travel" policy after reports showed that about 24.7 million motor vehicles—roughly 65 per cent nationwide—are either delinquent in registration or never registered (Top Gear Philippines, 2023). The financial cost of such unlicensed registers is enormous, amounting to approximately ₱37.1 billion as of April 2022 (The Philippine Star, 2023). Although national-level statistics on unlicensed driving and traffic crashes acknowledge the issue, the qualitative aspects (motivation, social pressures, perceptions) have not been studied in the country (Ayala & Aquino, 2023).

With the magnitude numbers of unregistered motor vehicle operation in the Philippines, and the risk profile of operating a unlicensed vehicle or non-registered

vehicle internationally known, there is a gap in knowledge regarding how people have the experience of such actions: what triggers their choice to drive without a license or not to have their vehicles registered; how they perceive risk and legality and enforcement; how cultural, economic, social and institutional forces interact in their decision-making (Partulan et al., 2024b).

Specifically, these lived experiences might not coincide with those found in national aggregate data in particular communities, such as Saint Michael College of Caraga, which have socioeconomic, geographic, or institutional contexts. Lacking a qualitative understanding, poorly crafted policies can be ineffective: enforcement alone might not work; education, access, or infrastructure might need to be improved, but we should not act without knowing how people experience those issues. Thus, this paper will discuss the experiences of unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles among the SMCC population and determine the motivations, effects, coping styles, and bases of the sense of legitimacy and perceived risk.

There are some possible contributions to this research. Socially, it can help educate policymakers, law enforcers, and regulatory authorities (including the LTO) on the non-legal aspects of noncompliance: what motivates or demotivates compliance in the eyes of the affected. In the scholarly sense, it bridges a qualitative gap in research on illegal driving and unregistered vehicles in the Philippines and augments many quantitative studies with narrative, experience-

based data on criminal behavior, compliance, risk perception, and regulatory behavior, thereby informing theory (Hertwig & Wulff, 2022).

In industry (such as vehicle registration services, driving schools, or community advocacy groups), the results can inform outreach, education, or intervention programs based on community conditions. In addition, this ongoing research can benefit the community by refining more humane, context-specific approaches to mitigating unregistered vehicle use and unlicensed driving, thereby minimizing people's exposure to road risks across the broader population.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

The issue is about unlicensed driving and unregistered vehicles. It is getting much attention now. People care about road safety, law, and social life. Global research links having a valid license and registration to fewer crashes. This shows the high risks and costs of these practices.

This part reviews past studies. It places our work in a bigger context. It shows key findings and gaps. These gaps mean we need a local study. This study will focus on the Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC) community.

Lived Mobility

Recent scholarship has increasingly framed lived mobility as a critical lens for understanding how individuals experience movement within intersecting social, legal, and institutional constraints. To begin with, Cresswell (2020)

emphasizes that mobility extends beyond physical movement and is instead a socially constructed experience shaped by power relations, regulation, and differential access. From this perspective, the act of driving—whether licensed or unlicensed—reflects broader inequalities in who is permitted to move freely and under what conditions. Accordingly, individuals who drive without licenses or vehicle registration often experience mobility as a negotiated practice, balancing everyday necessity, fear of enforcement, and social obligation.

Building on this conceptualization, Sheller (2021) highlights how everyday transportation practices are embedded not only in legal frameworks but also in moral judgments, governance structures, and economic realities. She further explains that in contexts where licensing and registration processes are costly, complex, or inaccessible, individuals may normalize noncompliance as a practical or survival-oriented response. Thus, unlicensed driving can be understood not merely as deviant behavior but as a reaction to structural exclusion, particularly in developing or semi-urban settings.

Similarly, Lucas (2020), in her qualitative work on transport marginalization, demonstrates that mobility restrictions disproportionately affect low-income populations, often pushing them toward informal or illegal mobility practices. Her findings further suggest that individuals frequently perceive legal requirements as disconnected from their lived realities, especially when mobility is essential for work, education, or family responsibilities. This reinforces the argument that

unlicensed driving and unregistered vehicle use are shaped by everyday pressures and limited alternatives, underscoring the importance of examining lived experiences rather than relying solely on enforcement statistics.

Expanding the discussion to the emotional dimension of mobility, Adey et al. (2021) conceptualize lived mobility as an embodied experience influenced by emotions such as fear, anxiety, and resilience. Their work indicates that individuals operating outside legal frameworks often develop heightened risk awareness and coping strategies to avoid detection. These emotional and psychological dimensions, including constant vigilance and stress, are frequently absent in quantitative traffic studies yet are crucial in understanding how illegal driving practices are sustained over time.

From a criminological perspective, Urry and Dennis (2022) connect lived mobility with everyday law-breaking and regulatory compliance. They argue that mobility-related offenses are often perceived as "necessary violations," particularly when institutional systems fail to accommodate citizens' needs. Consequently, individuals construct personal definitions of legitimacy, wherein moral justification may override formal legality. This insight is especially relevant to unlicensed drivers who may view their actions as practical solutions rather than criminal acts.

In relation to decision-making and risk, Hertwig and Wulff (2022) examine how individuals assess danger in everyday contexts. Their findings reveal that

repeated engagement in illegal mobility practices often leads individuals to downplay long-term risks while prioritizing immediate benefits. Applied to unregistered vehicle use, this suggests that lived mobility is shaped by experiential learning, where past success in avoiding apprehension reinforces continued noncompliance.

Finally, situating lived mobility within a regional context, Partulan et al. (2024) offer a Southeast Asian perspective that highlights the intersection of cultural norms, weak enforcement, and economic precarity in shaping illegal driving behaviors. Their qualitative findings demonstrate that in many communities, unlicensed driving is socially tolerated and even normalized. Taken together, these studies emphasize the need for localized, experience-based research—such as the present study at Saint Michael College of Caraga—to capture how lived mobility is understood, negotiated, and practiced within specific institutional, cultural, and community contexts.

Socioeconomic Factors

Socioeconomic factors play a critical role in shaping individuals' compliance with traffic laws, particularly in relation to driver licensing and vehicle registration. To begin with, Van Schagen and Goldenbeld (2020) found that individuals from lower-income groups are more likely to engage in illegal driving behaviors due to limited access to formal licensing systems and persistent financial constraints. Their study highlights that economic hardship often forces individuals to prioritize

immediate survival needs—such as employment and family support—over legal compliance, rendering unlicensed driving a pragmatic, though unlawful, choice.

Expanding on this argument, Mattioli et al. (2020), in their qualitative analysis of transport inequality, demonstrated that poverty and the lack of affordable transportation alternatives significantly influence risky and illegal mobility practices. They argue that when public transport systems are inadequate or inaccessible, marginalized individuals increasingly rely on private vehicles, even when they cannot afford registration fees, insurance, or licensing costs. This finding reinforces the notion that unregistered vehicle use is not merely a legal issue but a manifestation of broader socioeconomic exclusion.

Similarly, Delbosc and Currie (2021) examined the relationship between employment status and transport behavior, revealing that individuals working in informal or unstable labor sectors are more likely to drive without proper documentation. According to their findings, irregular income makes compliance with regulatory requirements financially unattainable, leading individuals to weigh the cost of compliance against the perceived risk of apprehension. Consequently, economic insecurity directly shapes decision-making related to illegal driving practices.

In the context of developing countries, Pojani and Stead (2021) further emphasize that weak institutional support systems and high compliance costs exacerbate existing socioeconomic inequalities in mobility. Their research indicates

that individuals from lower socioeconomic backgrounds often perceive traffic regulations as unfairly burdensome and disconnected from their lived realities. As a result, noncompliance becomes normalized within certain communities, particularly where enforcement is inconsistent and social tolerance for illegal driving is high.

Adding another dimension, Nguyen et al. (2022) explored the relationship between education level and traffic law compliance. Their study revealed that limited formal education is associated with lower awareness of traffic laws and reduced understanding of the long-term risks of unlicensed driving. When combined with financial hardship, this lack of legal literacy increases the likelihood of operating unregistered vehicles, especially among young adults and individuals in rural areas.

From a criminological standpoint, Farrall and Gray (2023) explain that socioeconomic strain often contributes to what they term “everyday law-breaking,” wherein individuals violate minor laws as coping mechanisms. They argue that traffic-related offenses, such as driving without a license, are frequently perceived as low-level and necessary violations rather than serious crimes. This perception, shaped by low income, family responsibilities, and limited access to state services, further normalizes noncompliance within economically constrained populations.

Finally, situating these findings within the Southeast Asian and Philippine context, Partulan et al. (2024) examined the socioeconomic determinants of illegal driving practices. Their qualitative findings show that high registration fees, complex bureaucratic procedures, and the lack of accessible LTO offices disproportionately burden low-income individuals. Consequently, unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles emerge as adaptive strategies to socioeconomic constraints rather than deliberate acts of defiance against the law.

Social Influence

Social influence plays a significant role in shaping individuals' driving behaviors and their compliance with traffic laws. To begin with, study emphasize that people are strongly guided by social norms, particularly descriptive norms that reflect what others commonly do. In traffic contexts, when individuals observe peers, family members, or community members driving without licenses or using unregistered vehicles without facing consequences, such behaviors gradually become normalized and perceived as acceptable. As a result, the deterrent effect of traffic laws is weakened, increasing the likelihood of imitation (Cialdini et al., 2021).

Building on this understanding, Gössling et al. (2020) argue that everyday mobility practices are socially learned and continuously reinforced through interaction. Their study suggests that driving behaviors are often transmitted informally through family and peer networks rather than acquired through formal

training or legal instruction. Consequently, individuals may adopt illegal driving practices early in life, especially when influential figures model unlicensed driving as a routine or necessary activity.

Similarly, Moller and Haustein (2021) examined the role of peer influence in risky driving behavior and found that individuals are more likely to violate traffic rules when their social groups tolerate or even support such actions. This peer reinforcement reduces feelings of guilt, fear, or moral conflict associated with noncompliance. In communities where unlicensed driving is widespread, social acceptance often outweighs legal considerations, shaping driving decisions more strongly than formal regulations.

From a criminological perspective, Wikström et al. (2021) highlight how social environments influence moral perceptions of legality and crime. Their situational action theory proposes that individuals are more likely to engage in illegal acts when their social context frames such behavior as morally acceptable. Applied to unlicensed driving, this perspective suggests that social influence can redefine the act as a minor, justified, or even necessary offense rather than a serious legal violation.

In developing-country settings, Pojani et al. (2022) further note that social influence is particularly powerful in contexts characterized by weak enforcement and strong community ties. Their research demonstrates that collective practices—such as sharing strategies to avoid checkpoints or exchanging informal

advice on driving without documentation—reinforce illegal mobility behaviors. These shared practices strengthen group norms that prioritize practicality and survival over legal compliance.

Adding to this discussion, Nguyen et al. (2022) found that family pressure plays a critical role in encouraging unlicensed driving, particularly among younger individuals. Their study reveals that family members may actively encourage driving without a license to meet economic or household demands, reinforcing the idea that social obligation and responsibility can override legal requirements.

Finally, contextualizing these findings within Southeast Asia, Partulan et al. (2024) examined social influence in traffic behavior and found that community tolerance and peer validation are central to sustaining unlicensed driving practices. Participants reported learning illegal driving behaviors from friends and neighbors and relying on shared knowledge to manage risks. Taken together, these findings highlight how social influence shapes not only driving behavior but also perceptions of risk, legitimacy, and necessity in everyday illegal mobility practices.

Risk Perception

Risk perception plays a crucial role in shaping individuals' decisions to comply with or violate traffic laws. To begin with, De Winter and Dodou (2020) explain that drivers' perceptions of risk are often subjective and influenced more by personal experience than by objective safety data. Their findings indicate that individuals who repeatedly engage in risky or illegal behaviors without

experiencing negative consequences tend to perceive these actions as less dangerous. This helps explain why unlicensed drivers or operators of unregistered vehicles may persist in such practices despite being aware of the associated legal and safety risks.

Extending this argument, Hertwig and Wulff (2022) describe the description–experience gap, wherein individuals rely more heavily on lived experiences than on statistical or informational warnings when assessing danger. Applied to illegal driving, individuals who have consistently avoided apprehension or accidents may underestimate the likelihood of harm or punishment. Consequently, this experiential learning reinforces continued noncompliance, as the absence of immediate consequences reshapes how drivers evaluate both risk and legality.

In addition to personal experience, enforcement practices significantly influence risk perception. For instance, Useche et al. (2021), in a qualitative study on road safety behavior, found that perceived enforcement intensity strongly affects how drivers assess risk. When law enforcement is inconsistent or predictable, drivers tend to believe that the likelihood of being caught is low. As a result, behaviors such as driving without a license or operating unregistered vehicles become more common, particularly in communities where such practices are widespread and socially tolerated.

Moreover, Truelove et al. (2020) emphasize the role of social context in shaping risk perception. Their research demonstrates that individuals often normalize risky behaviors when peers and community members engage in similar actions without repercussions. Within such environments, unlicensed driving is viewed as a manageable or acceptable risk rather than a serious legal violation. This normalization further weakens the deterrent effect of traffic laws and alters individual judgments regarding safety and compliance.

From a criminological perspective, Bottoms and Tankebe (2021) argue that perceptions of authority legitimacy strongly influence how individuals interpret legal risk. Specifically, when drivers perceive regulatory institutions as unfair, inaccessible, or ineffective, they are less likely to view traffic violations as morally or legally risky. Instead, concerns shift toward avoiding inconvenience, financial loss, or disruption of daily routines, thereby contributing to the persistence of illegal driving behaviors.

Furthermore, Fleiter et al. (2022) highlight the interaction between socioeconomic stress and risk-taking in traffic contexts. Their findings suggest that individuals experiencing financial pressure are more willing to accept higher levels of risk—including legal risk—to meet essential mobility needs. This indicates that risk perception among unlicensed drivers is not purely cognitive but is shaped by necessity, where immediate benefits are prioritized over potential long-term consequences.

Finally, situating these findings within a regional context, Partulan et al. (2024) demonstrate how cultural familiarity with traffic violations influences risk perception in Southeast Asian settings. Their qualitative results reveal that repeated exposure to unlicensed driving and weak enforcement reduces fear of sanctions and accidents. Over time, drivers develop adaptive coping strategies—such as avoiding checkpoints or traveling during low-enforcement hours—which further reinforce the persistence and normalization of illegal driving practices.

Legal Awareness

Legal awareness refers to an individual's knowledge, understanding, and interpretation of laws and regulations that govern behavior in society. According to Tyler and Trinkner (2020), individuals who possess higher levels of legal awareness are more likely to comply with laws voluntarily, as they better understand both the purpose of regulations and the consequences of violations. In the context of traffic laws, limited awareness of licensing and registration requirements may lead individuals to unintentionally engage in illegal driving practices, especially in communities where formal legal education is minimal.

McAdams (2021) emphasizes that legal awareness is not solely about knowing the law but also about how individuals perceive its relevance to their daily lives. His work suggests that when laws are viewed as complex, inaccessible, or detached from social realities, people are less motivated to comply. This is particularly evident in traffic regulation, where drivers may be aware that licensing

is required but lack clear understanding of procedures, penalties, or long-term implications of noncompliance.

In a study on traffic law compliance, Zhang et al. (2021) found that drivers with low legal literacy were significantly more likely to commit violations, including unlicensed driving. Their findings indicate that misinformation, informal knowledge-sharing, and reliance on community norms often replace accurate legal understanding. As a result, individuals may underestimate the seriousness of driving without a license or using unregistered vehicles.

From a developing-country perspective, Boateng and Agyemang (2022) argue that weak dissemination of legal information contributes to widespread noncompliance with traffic laws. Their qualitative findings reveal that many drivers are unaware of recent policy changes, registration deadlines, or penalty structures. This lack of legal awareness is compounded by limited access to government offices and ineffective public information campaigns, leading to habitual violations.

In the field of criminology, Bottoms and Tankebe (2021) link legal awareness to perceptions of legitimacy and authority. They argue that individuals who do not clearly understand the law are less likely to internalize legal norms. Instead, compliance becomes dependent on fear of punishment rather than moral obligation. This dynamic is evident among unlicensed drivers who may comply only when enforcement is visible, suggesting that legal awareness influences both attitudes and behavior.

Papachristos et al. (2022) further note that legal awareness develops through interaction with the justice system. Their research shows that individuals who have never undergone formal licensing or registration processes often lack practical understanding of legal procedures. This experiential gap reinforces avoidance behavior, where drivers continue operating illegally to evade perceived bureaucratic difficulty or embarrassment.

Finally, Partulan et al. (2024) highlight the role of legal awareness in Southeast Asian traffic contexts. Their study found that many drivers possess fragmented or inaccurate knowledge of licensing and registration laws, often relying on hearsay rather than official sources. This limited awareness, combined with economic constraints and weak enforcement, contributes to the normalization of unlicensed driving and unregistered vehicle use within certain communities.

Law Enforcement

Law enforcement plays a central role in shaping compliance with traffic laws, particularly in relation to driver licensing and vehicle registration. According to Mazerolle et al. (2020), the visibility and consistency of law enforcement significantly influence drivers' willingness to obey traffic regulations. Their study suggests that when enforcement is perceived as weak or inconsistent, drivers are more likely to engage in violations such as unlicensed driving, as the perceived likelihood of apprehension is low.

De Angelis and Grimshaw (2021) emphasize that enforcement strategies are most effective when they are perceived as fair and impartial. Their research indicates that aggressive or selective enforcement can undermine public trust, leading drivers to resist compliance rather than internalize legal norms. In the context of unregistered vehicles, drivers may view enforcement as punitive rather than corrective, which affects their long-term compliance behavior.

In a study on traffic policing, Haghshenas et al. (2021) found that routine checkpoints and random inspections increase drivers' perception of enforcement certainty, thereby reducing illegal driving practices. However, they also note that drivers quickly adapt to predictable enforcement patterns by altering routes or travel times. This adaptive behavior highlights the dynamic relationship between law enforcement practices and drivers' lived experiences of regulation.

From a criminological standpoint, Tyler (2021) argues that enforcement effectiveness depends not only on punishment but also on perceived legitimacy. When law enforcers are viewed as legitimate authorities, individuals are more likely to comply voluntarily with laws, including licensing and registration requirements. Conversely, distrust in law enforcement encourages avoidance behaviors, such as driving without documents to evade interaction with authorities.

In developing-country contexts, Piquero et al. (2022) highlight that limited resources and understaffed traffic enforcement units reduce the deterrent effect

of traffic laws. Their findings suggest that inconsistent enforcement creates opportunities for habitual violations, particularly among economically disadvantaged drivers who rely heavily on private vehicles for livelihood. This underscores the structural challenges faced by law enforcement agencies in addressing unlicensed driving.

Useche, Montoro, and Alonso (2022) further explain that drivers' previous encounters with law enforcement shape their future compliance. Negative experiences, such as perceived harassment or corruption, lower respect for traffic authorities and increase tolerance for illegal driving practices. This experiential aspect of enforcement is crucial in understanding why some drivers persist in operating unlicensed or unregistered vehicles.

Finally, Partulan et al. (2024) examined law enforcement and traffic compliance in Southeast Asia, including the Philippines. Their qualitative findings reveal that weak enforcement, informal settlements, and social familiarity between enforcers and drivers contribute to the normalization of traffic violations. Drivers often rely on personal strategies—such as avoiding checkpoints or leveraging social connections—to manage enforcement risks, reinforcing continued noncompliance.

Safety and Agency

Safety and agency are closely intertwined in mobility studies, particularly in understanding how individuals exercise control over their movement despite

legal and structural constraints. According to Bandura (2021), agency refers to an individual's capacity to act intentionally and make choices within given circumstances. In the context of road use, drivers often assert agency by deciding when and how to travel, even when such decisions involve legal risks. For unlicensed drivers, operating a vehicle may be perceived as an assertion of autonomy and necessity rather than recklessness, especially when mobility is essential for livelihood or family responsibilities.

Sheller (2021) emphasizes that perceptions of safety are subjective and shaped by lived experience rather than formal regulations alone. Her work suggests that individuals may feel personally "safe" while driving without a license if they are familiar with routes, traffic patterns, and enforcement practices. This sense of perceived safety can coexist with legal unsafety, revealing a gap between institutional definitions of road safety and drivers' everyday assessments of risk and control.

In a qualitative study on transport behavior, Brown and Spinney (2020) found that individuals often redefine safety based on competence and experience rather than legality. Drivers who have long operated vehicles without formal credentials tend to rely on self-assessed driving skills to justify their actions. This reinforces the role of agency, where confidence in one's abilities reduces perceived danger and legitimizes continued unlicensed driving.

From a public health perspective, Rhodes and Pivik (2022) argue that safety-related decisions are influenced by trade-offs between immediate needs and long-term risk. Their findings indicate that individuals facing economic or social pressure may prioritize agency—such as the ability to travel freely—over compliance with safety regulations. In such cases, driving without proper documentation becomes a calculated decision shaped by necessity rather than disregard for safety.

In criminological literature, Farrall, Hunter, Sharpe, and Calverley (2021) explain that everyday rule-breaking can function as a form of adaptive agency. Their research shows that individuals often navigate structural limitations by selectively complying with laws they perceive as flexible or negotiable. Traffic laws, particularly those related to licensing and registration, are frequently viewed as administrative rather than moral, allowing drivers to maintain a sense of personal safety while violating formal rules.

Useche et al. (2022) further highlight that perceived control over driving situations strongly affects safety behavior. Their study found that drivers who believe they can manage hazards—such as avoiding accidents or checkpoints—are more willing to accept legal and physical risks. This perceived agency reduces fear and increases tolerance for unsafe or illegal practices, including driving without a license or operating unregistered vehicles.

Finally, Partulan et al. (2024) provide a Southeast Asian perspective on safety and agency in illegal driving practices. Their qualitative findings reveal that many drivers view unlicensed driving as a necessary exercise of agency in environments where legal compliance is costly or inaccessible. While participants acknowledged potential dangers, they emphasized personal judgment, experience, and adaptability as key factors in maintaining safety. This highlights how safety is constructed through lived experience and agency rather than solely through adherence to legal standards.

1.3 Conceptual Framework

This study builds on the idea that personal, social, and institutional factors work together to influence unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles. These factors shape how people view and engage in these practices within their communities. According to Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory (1979) (El Zaatari & Maalouf, 2022), human behavior is influenced by multiple layers, ranging from individual traits to wider social and institutional systems. Thus, personal motivations, social dynamics, and institutional conditions collectively shape the experiences of those involved in unlicensed driving and vehicle use (Mary & Antony, 2022).

This qualitative conceptual framework seeks to interpret the meanings, contexts, and realities that underlie these behaviors. The study is based on books, field observations, and the actual experiences of drivers. The framework focuses

on understanding how people make sense of their actions and how their environment influences their decisions rather than on testing hypotheses or predicting outcomes (Neal & Neal, 2013).

The Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991) helps explain how individuals make decisions. It shows that people's actions are influenced by their attitudes (how they feel about the behavior), their confidence in being able to do or avoid it, and the expectations or pressures from others around them. In this study, TPB helps explain why members of the SMCC community choose to comply—or not—with licensing and registration laws, showing that decisions are shaped not only by personal choice but also by social and institutional realities (Ajzen, 2020).

By combining these perspectives, the framework explains how institutions, social norms, and personal choices interact to shape people's real-life experiences with unlicensed driving and the set of unregistered vehicles. It offers a framework for analyzing participant narratives and comprehending how the socioeconomic and cultural circumstances of the SMCC community as a whole affects people's conduct.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

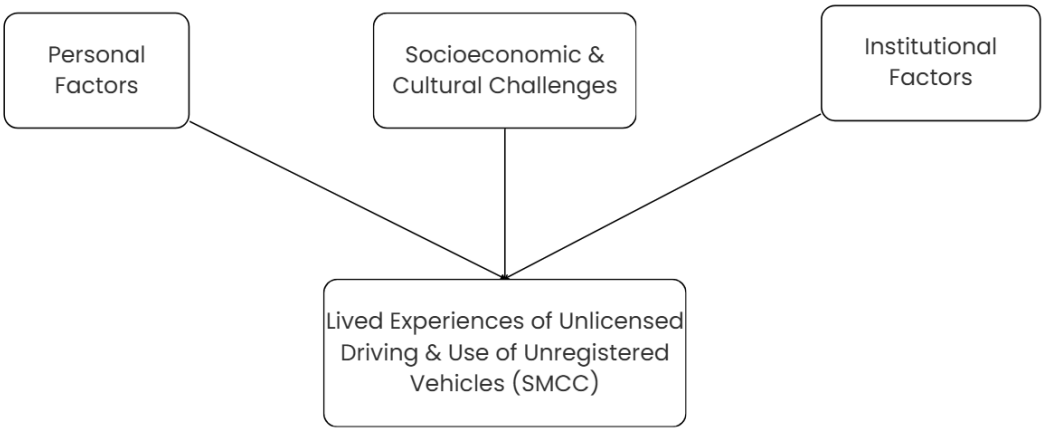


Figure 2. ***The Schematic Diagram***

The schematic diagram illustrates the interconnected relationships among personal, socioeconomic, cultural, and institutional factors that collectively shape the lived experiences of unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles within the SMCC community.

This framework reflects the dynamic and multi-layered nature of human behavior. Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory (1979) shows that people do not make decisions on their own but are influenced by their surroundings—from their personal environment to larger social and institutional systems. It shows that a person's decisions depend on their environment, from close personal settings to wider social and institutional systems.

These factors include attitudes, motivations, beliefs, and perceptions of risk. Some drivers justify their behavior by citing convenience, financial reasons, or the belief that law enforcement is weak. According to the Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991), attitudes, perceived control over the behavior, and social pressures all influence actions. People are more likely to drive illegally if they have a positive attitude toward it and believe that others are doing the same. People are more likely to disobey when they are confident that they won't be punished.

Unlicensed and unregistered driving is shaped by social, economic, and cultural factors. Many people struggle to afford registration or licensing fees because of financial hardship, unemployment, or unstable income. Community customs and cultural norms are just as significant as economics. When many people start engaging in these behaviors and society begins to accept them, they slowly come normalized and no longer seen as wrong (Tong and An,2024).

Berger and Luckman (1966) argue that social realities are constructed and sustained through shared meanings and interactions. Within the SMCC community, repeated social validation—through family members, peers, or neighbors who engage in similar practices—creates a collective understanding that driving without proper documentation is a necessary and acceptable response to local socioeconomic challenges. This way, culture and circumstance merge to normalize noncompliance as a survival strategy rather than a deliberate violation.

Institutional factors refer to the systems and rules that influence individual choices and community behavior. These include the accessibility and efficiency of Land Transportation Office (LTO) services, the fairness and consistency of law enforcement, and the level of public trust in government institutions. When people encounter long delays, hard-to-reach offices, or inconsistent and biased enforcement, their trust in these institutions tends to decline (Valerio A.,2024).

According to Boulagouas et al. (2020a), when trust in legal institutions declines, individuals are less likely to follow regulations voluntarily. In such situations, noncompliance can be seen as a rational response to perceived inefficiencies or unfairness in the system. As a result, institutional shortcomings indirectly contribute to the continued cycle of unlicensed driving and unregistered vehicle use, as people prioritize practicality and necessity over formal compliance.

Drawing on Bronfenbrenner's ecological perspective, this framework emphasizes that no single factor can fully explain unlicensed driving and vehicle non-registration. Instead, these behaviors result from the interaction of multiple levels of influence—individual motivations at the micro level, social norms at the meso-level, and institutional conditions at the macro level. This perspective highlights how human behavior is shaped by interconnected systems that influence opportunities, limitations, and perceptions of the law (Bronfenbrenner, 1979).

Combining Social Constructionism (Berger & Luckmann, 1966) with the Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, 1991) helps explain this more clearly. These theories show that driving behavior is shaped by personal beliefs, shared social meanings, and people's sense of control. Following traffic laws, therefore, depends not only on personal values but also on institutional rules and community norms (Berger & Luckmann, 1966; Ajzen, 1991). Unlicensed driving is a socially and contextually rooted behavior that is impacted by both individual cognition and larger systemic conditions, as this integrated framework makes clear.

General Objective

To explore and understand the lived experiences of individuals within the SMCC community regarding the use of unlicensed driving and unregistered vehicles, in their personal, social, and institutional contexts.

Specific Objectives

1. To explore how individuals engaged in unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles describe their lived experiences in navigating daily mobility and transportation demands.

2. To identify the personal, social, economic, and contextual factors that influence individuals' decisions to operate a vehicle without a valid driver's license or without proper registration.

3. To examine how participants interpret and make sense of the risks, consequences, and moral or legal implications associated with unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles.

4. To determine how these lived experiences shape individuals' perceptions of safety, law enforcement, community relations, and their sense of responsibility and agency.

1.5 Definition of Terms

To help understand, the researchers define the following terms operationally to determine their technical meaning.

Attitudes – This refers to the beliefs, feelings, and evaluations of members of the SMCC community toward driving without a license and using unregistered vehicles, as shaped by their personal experiences and social environment.

Compliance – This refers to the degree to which individuals follow or fail to follow government licensing and vehicle registration regulations, as described through their lived experiences.

Coping Strategies – This refers to the methods, behaviors, or rationalizations individuals use to manage, justify, or continue driving without a license or using an unregistered vehicle, such as avoiding law enforcement or minimizing perceived risks.

Institutional Factors – This refers to the influence of government systems, accessibility of LTO services, law enforcement practices, and public trust in authorities on individuals' compliance with licensing and vehicle registration requirements.

Lived Experiences – This refers to the personal narratives, perceptions, and accounts shared by members of the SMCC community regarding their involvement in unlicensed driving or the use of unregistered vehicles.

Motivations – This refers to the reasons individuals give for engaging in unlicensed driving or using unregistered vehicles, including financial constraints, convenience, and influence from peers or social circles.

Personal Factors – This refers to individual-level reasons, needs, or justifications that influence engagement in unlicensed driving or the use of unregistered vehicles, such as financial limitations, personal convenience, or perceived necessity.

Risk Perception – This refers to how individuals assess and interpret the potential legal, financial, and safety risks associated with driving without a license or using an unregistered vehicle.

Social Factors – This refers to the influence of family, peers, and community norms on individuals' attitudes and behaviors toward unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles, including the extent to which these practices are socially accepted or normalized.

SMCC Community – This refers to students, staff, and other individuals affiliated with Saint Michael College of Caraga who are involved in or have knowledge of unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles.

Unlicensed Driving – This refers to the operation of a motor vehicle by members of the SMCC community without possessing a valid driver's license issued by the Land Transportation Office (LTO).

Unregistered Vehicle – This refers to any motor vehicle, including motorcycles, tricycles, cars, or vans, used within the SMCC community that has not been properly registered, renewed, or recorded with the Land Transportation Office (LTO) in accordance with government regulations.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

In this chapter, the researcher has discussed the methods and procedures used to conduct the research. It presents the study plan, setting, subjects, data-collection methodologies, and data-analysis procedures that informed the investigation. Since the survey aims to understand the real experiences of people who drive without a license or use unregistered vehicles in the SMCC community, the study uses a qualitative approach to explore and reflect on their voices, views, and situations. The approaches mentioned in this chapter will make the research process systematic, credible, and consistent with the study objectives.

2.1 Research Design

This research uses a phenomenological design, which is well-suited for exploring and understanding people's real-life experiences. Phenomenology, a qualitative approach, focuses on how individuals perceive, interpret, and make sense of specific experiences (Creswell & Poth, 2017). It seeks to uncover the true essence of these experiences through the participants' own stories and perspectives.

According to Creswell and Poth (as cited in Alhazmi & Kaufmann, 2022), the main goal of a phenomenological study is to describe the shared experiences of people who have gone through the same phenomenon. This method is effective

when the research focuses on people's everyday experiences and how they interpret them.

A phenomenological approach is particularly appropriate for this study because the phenomenon of unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles within the SMCC community is deeply rooted in individuals' lived realities rather than merely in legal non-compliance. These behaviors are shaped by personal meanings, social acceptance, perceived necessity, and everyday interactions with institutional systems such as law enforcement and licensing agencies. By using phenomenology, the study captures how participants experience, interpret, and rationalize these practices in their daily lives, allowing the researcher to understand the essence of the phenomenon from the participants' own perspectives rather than imposing external judgments or assumptions.

Moreover, this design enables the exploration of shared patterns across participants, such as common motivations, perceived risks, coping strategies, and social influences that sustain unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles. Phenomenology allows the researcher to bracket preconceived notions about legality and focus instead on how participants construct meaning around compliance, risk, and responsibility within their social and institutional context. Through in-depth narratives, the study gains a deeper understanding of why these practices persist despite existing regulations, providing insights that are essential

for developing context-sensitive interventions, policy recommendations, and institutional responses that reflect the realities of the SMCC community.

2.2 Research Materials and Methods

The research instrument used in this study was a semi-structured interview guide, developed by the researcher to collect in-depth qualitative data on participants' lived experiences of unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles. The interview guide consisted of carefully constructed open-ended questions that focused on participants' motivations, perceptions, coping strategies, and interactions with traffic regulations and enforcement. Although the guide provided a structured flow, it allowed flexibility for follow-up questions to further explore emerging ideas and clarify participants' responses.

Data were collected through individual, face-to-face semi-structured interviews conducted in a quiet and private setting within the SMCC community or in another location convenient to the participant. With informed consent, all interviews were audio-recorded to ensure accurate documentation of participants' responses. During the interviews, the researcher also took field notes to capture non-verbal cues, emotional expressions, and contextual observations that could not be fully reflected in audio recordings.

After data collection, the recorded interviews were transcribed verbatim using transcription software and Microsoft Word. These transcripts served as the primary data for thematic analysis. Relevant books, peer-reviewed journal articles,

and government reports were consulted only to support interpretation and discussion of findings, not as data sources.

2.3 Research Environment, Population, and Sample

The study will be conducted in Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC) in Nasipit, Agusan del Norte, Philippines. SMCC is an institution that provides undergraduate, graduate, and basic education to students of various municipalities within the Caraga Region; the institution is privately owned. There are students, faculty, staff, and other stakeholders in the community. A lot of them ride motorcycles, tricycles, and their own cars. The setting is appropriate because driving without a license and using vehicles that are not registered are common in provincial areas, where economic and institutional factors make it hard to follow traffic laws. For this reason, SMCC is a good place to study.

Population

The population sample to be used in this study is the members of the SMCC community who directly or indirectly experience unlicensed driving or using unregistered vehicles. This includes:

a) Students who drive or ride on unregistered vehicles.
b) Participants include staff and faculty members who either personally engage in driving or riding practices, or who have direct knowledge or observations of unlicensed driving and the use of unregistered vehicles within the SMCC community.

Despite the large composition of the SMCC community, only those with pertinent experiences or who are aware of the phenomenon are included in the study population.

Sample

The research applies the purposive sampling method in a qualitative study where the participants are selected deliberately depending on their knowledge, experience, or participation in the phenomenon to be studied. The target group will consist of SMCC community students, faculty, and staff members who have direct or indirect experience with unlicensed driving or driving unregistered vehicles.

A total of 10–15 participants will be chosen to reach data saturation—the point when no new ideas or themes appear in the interviews. This approach helps the researchers gather a wide range of meaningful perspectives. Purposive sampling is commonly used in phenomenological studies because it focuses on people with profound, first-hand experiences (Creswell & Poth, 2018).

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

This study adopts a qualitative data analysis approach consistent with phenomenological research. The primary method is thematic analysis, which seeks to identify, analyze, and interpret patterns of meaning (themes) across the participants' narratives.

Data Processing

All interviews were audio-recorded with the participants' permission and then transcribed exactly as spoken. The researchers carefully checked the transcript against the recordings to ensure accuracy. Responses in local languages were translated into English while keeping their original meaning. The researchers also included field notes and direct observations in the dataset.

Data Analysis

The analysis follows the steps outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006) for thematic analysis:

Familiarisation – Reading and re-reading transcripts to immerse yourself in the data and gain an overall understanding of participants' experiences.

Generating Initial Codes – Systematically coding significant statements, phrases, and patterns related to unlicensed driving and unregistered vehicle use.

Searching for Themes – Organizing related codes into broader categories or themes, such as motivations, perceptions of legality, social pressures, and coping strategies.

Reviewing Themes – Refining and merging themes to make sure they accurately reflect the data.

Defining and Naming Themes Finalizing the themes and giving them clear, descriptive labels that capture the core meaning of each one.

Producing the Report – Presenting the themes with supporting quotations from participants to highlight lived experiences.

Interpretation

The themes were analyzed with the study's objectives and conceptual framework in mind. The analysis highlights both the unique experiences of each participant and the ordinary meanings shared across participants, following the phenomenological approach described by Moustakas (1994).

Tools and Software

The researchers used Microsoft Word and Excel to transcribe data and organize codes. They manually coded the data to stay closely connected with it. If needed they could also use digital tool like Atlas. To categorize themes and retrieve information more efficiently.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

This study follows the highest ethical standards to fully protect the rights, dignity, and well-being of all participants throughout the research process. The researchers follow these key principles in conducting the study:

Protection of Intellectual Property Rights (IPR): The researchers respect intellectual property rights by recognizing that all the research tools, interview guides, and analytical frameworks they created are original materials protected by Philippine copyright law and cannot be used without permission. Every reference,

work, and source is correctly cited and acknowledged. No patent or trademark registration is required because the study does not involve the creation of a new product, brand, or technology. This approach helps eliminate plagiarism and ensures that the intellectual contributions of researchers and others are appropriately acknowledged.

Informed Consent: The study ensured that all of its participants—SMCC students, faculty, and staff—understood its purpose, goals, and methodology before data collection. The researchers clearly explained that participation was voluntary and fully described the possible risks and benefits. Each participant received a written consent form to sign before the interviews began, written in simple and easy-to-understand language. The researchers informed the participants that they could withdraw from the study at any time without any penalty or negative consequence. Because the study involved human participants instead of animals or other living organisms, the researchers did not need additional ethical approval for animal welfare.

Data Privacy and Confidentiality: A priority for all the data collected. The final report does not include names, addresses, and contact details as personal identifiers. The use of pseudonyms or participant codes maintains anonymity. The researchers store both physical and digital data in a secure place. The researchers protect digital files with passwords and keep paper documents in locked folders

that only they can access. The researchers will share the anonymized data for academic purposes, and only with the participants consent.

Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw: There will be no obligation to participate in this study. The researchers informed the participants that they could withdraw from the study at any time without facing any consequences. The study design will ensure that there is no coercion, influence, or outside pressure in obtaining participation. All interviews followed all the rules of silence, respect for the autonomy and comfort of the participants, and their readiness to share their experiences.

Minimization of Hard and Risk Management: The researchers carefully designed the interview questions to prevent any physical, emotional, or psychological harm to the participants. The study presents minimal risk because it only explores the participants' experiences and perceptions. If participants felt uncomfortable, they could choose not to answer specific questions or stop the interview at any time. The researchers followed the ethical principle of non-maleficence by ensuring that participation did not cause any harm or suffering.

Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge: This research will benefit both the academic and local communities by offering more profound insights into the factors that influence unlicensed driving and vehicle non-registration in SMCC. The results of this study aim to promote awareness, responsibility, and compliance with driving and registration regulations. Although the participants might not

receive direct benefits, their shared experiences will contribute to public knowledge and personal growth. They can also request a summary of the study's findings.

Justice and Fair Participant Selection: Using purposive sampling, participants were selected thoughtfully and fairly. The researchers included only individuals with relevant experiences to ensure a diverse and representative group from the SMCC community. The selection process was open and non-discriminatory, allowing everyone an equal chance to participate, regardless of gender, role, or social status.

Data Integrity and Accuracy: The researchers used standard qualitative methods for transcribing, coding, and analyzing data to ensure accuracy and maintain the integrity of the study. To reduce the risk of confusion or bias, all results were carefully reviewed and discussed. The researchers acknowledged the study's limitations and potential challenges. They clearly stated these limitations to ensure credibility and transparency. The researchers confirmed that all the data used in the study are genuine and not have been altered or fabricated.

Transparency and Honesty in Reporting: The results, interpretations, and conclusions of this study are based entirely on data collected from participants and relevant literature. The researchers did not falsify, exaggerate, or omit any information to mislead readers or support a specific viewpoint. To maintain transparency and integrity, the researchers acknowledged the study's limitations.

They also presented the findings fairly and without bias, accurately reflecting the participants' voices and experiences, free from personal or institutional influence.

Correct citation and reference: the researchers always did these things, which kept the study's credibility and prevented plagiarism.

Used Patented or Copyright Materials: The researchers properly cited all ideas, quotes, and rephrased information in the paper using the APA referencing style. The research report is honest and transparent, with no data hidden or changed. Any copyrighted materials, such as academic sources or digital tools, were used with permission and properly credited.

Considerations for Human Subjects: The researchers ensured that everyone from the Saint Michael College of Caraga community who participated in the study was treated with respect and keep safe. The people who took part in the study did so on their own, without anyone else forcing them to. No one was forced or unfairly influenced to take part; everyone did so of their own free will. Transcripts and reports used fictitious names to protect people's identities and personal information. No one was penalized for quitting at any point or for skipping questions. The researchers followed ethical standards at every stage of the study to protect each participant's rights, safety, and well-being, in line with institutional and ethical research guidelines.

Responsible use of AI and other Technologies: The study used responsible, licensed technologies to aid in the research process. In order to maintain human-

led and ethically sound, the researchers used Microsoft Copilot only for language assistance, not for generating data.

Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval: The Research Committee of Saint Michael College of Caraga reviewed and approved the research proposal before data collection. This approval ensures that the study complies with the institution's standards for research integrity, data privacy, and participant protection.